

How to Write an Abstract

WRITING GOOD ABSTRACTS

This article shall guide you on how to write a good abstract. It lists the six essential elements of a good abstract, the ideal number of words, and tense. The article ends with an example abstract of a real-life study with a supplemental video related to the findings.

After finishing your research paper, thesis, or scientific paper, there is a need for you to write the abstract. How is the abstract written? What are the essential elements of a good abstract? If this is your first time, or you don't feel confident about writing your first abstract, these tips are handy. I provide an example to demonstrate how it works.

Definition and Purpose of Abstracts

An abstract is a short summary of your (published or unpublished) research paper, usually about a paragraph (c. 6-7 sentences, 150-250 words) long. A well-written abstract serves multiple purposes:

- an abstract lets readers get the gist or essence of your paper or article quickly, in order to decide whether to read the full paper;
- an abstract prepares readers to follow the detailed information, analyses, and arguments in your full paper;
- and, later, an abstract helps readers remember key points from your paper.

It's also worth remembering that search engines and bibliographic databases use abstracts, as well as the title, to identify key terms for indexing your published paper. So what you include in your abstract and in your title are crucial for helping other researchers find your paper or article.

If you are writing an abstract for a course paper, your professor may give you specific guidelines for what to include and how to organize your abstract. Similarly, academic journals often have specific requirements for abstracts. So in addition to following the advice on this page, you should be sure to look for and follow any guidelines from the course or journal you're writing for.

The Contents of an Abstract

Abstracts contain most of the following kinds of information in brief form. The body of your paper will, of course, develop and explain these ideas much more fully. As you will see in the samples below, the proportion of your abstract that you devote to

each kind of information—and the sequence of that information—will vary, depending on the nature and genre of the paper that you are summarizing in your abstract. And in some cases, some of this information is implied, rather than stated explicitly. *The Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association*, which is widely used in the social sciences, gives specific guidelines for what to include in the abstract for different kinds of papers—for empirical studies, literature reviews or meta-analyses, theoretical papers, methodological papers, and case studies.

Here are the typical kinds of information found in most abstracts:

1. the context or background information for your research; the general topic under study; the specific topic of your research
2. the central questions or statement of the problem your research addresses
3. what's already known about this question, what previous research has done or shown
4. the main reason(s), the exigency, the rationale, the goals for your research—Why is it important to address these questions? Are you, for example, examining a new topic? Why is that topic worth examining? Are you filling a gap in previous research? Applying new methods to take a fresh look at existing ideas or data? Resolving a dispute within the literature in your field?
5. your research and/or analytical methods
6. your main findings, results, or arguments
7. the significance or implications of your findings or arguments.

Your abstract should be intelligible on its own, without a reader's having to read your entire paper. And in an abstract, you usually do *not* cite references—most of your abstract will describe what *you* have studied in your research and what *you* have found and what *you* argue in your paper. In the body of your paper, you will cite the specific literature that informs your research.

When to Write Your Abstract

Although you might be tempted to write your abstract first because it will appear as the very first part of your paper, it's a good idea to wait to write your abstract until *after* you've drafted your full paper, so that you know what you're summarizing.

WHY WRITE THE ABSTRACT?

Abstracts are indispensable references for scientists or students working on their research proposal; particularly, in preparing their literature review.

The information provided in the abstract must be sufficient to help the researcher decide whether the work is relevant to his or her interest or not. It should be brief but not lacking in essential elements to foster an understanding of the research conducted. The abstract will also help the researcher decide whether to read the whole research paper or not.

● **DEFINITION OF AN ABSTRACT**

An abstract is a summary of your research paper, thesis, or scientific paper. The abstract describes an unpublished or published research study in capsule form. It is a brief overview of the investigation so that researchers can comprehend the content of the research quickly. A good abstract is a mini-version of the whole research paper.

● **SIX ESSENTIAL ELEMENTS OF A GOOD ABSTRACT**

So how should the abstract of a research paper be written so that readers will derive the maximum benefit from it?

In writing a good abstract, the critical sections of a research paper should be present. Generally, an informational abstract should sum up the main sections of the research paper, i.e., the introduction, the materials and methods used, the findings, the discussion, conclusions, and recommendations. Therefore, it should contain the following essential elements:

1. INTRODUCTION

The abstract should introduce the general domain or the key concepts of the research that is being described. This can include definitions, the general worldview of the concept, the problem that has been solved in that particular domain, etc.

2. OBJECTIVE, AIM, OR PURPOSE OF THE RESEARCH PAPER

This part of the abstract mentions the study's rationale. It states clearly the objective, aim, or purpose of the study. It answers the question: "Why do we care about the issue?". It states the problem statement or the central argument or thesis statement. The relevance of the study in society is highlighted. Why did the researchers undertake the research? What is at stake?

3. METHOD OR METHODOLOGY THAT STATES THE PROCEDURES USED IN THE CONDUCT OF THE STUDY

The method or methodology part concisely describes the method or methodology employed in gathering the data, processing, and analysis. It gives a brief description of how the researcher or group of researchers performed the investigation. It includes the number of samples, instruments, and statistical tests used to analyze the data for quantitative research. This part also gives a hint on the scope of the study.

4. RESULTS OR MAJOR FINDINGS

This portion of the abstract summarizes the results or major findings of the study. It only states the significant results, most important ones, or highlights of the study in a sentence or a few sentences.

You can cite the probability values here to show the significance of computed correlations or differences. It emphasizes the practical importance of the findings; and how those findings will add or enhance the body of knowledge on the issue.

5. CONCLUSION

This part of the research abstract states the principal conclusion of the study. After obtaining the findings, what did the researchers conclude?

The conclusion, in particular, should be given special attention in writing the abstract. The conclusion should be well supported by the findings of the investigation; not a sweeping statement without any valid argument or evidence to back it up.

6. FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

Future implications of recommendations to extend the research under consideration following the conclusion of the research.

● NUMBER OF WORDS

Abstracts should not exceed 250 words, but this number could vary depending on the prescribed number of words, say when you would like to submit your research paper to a popular scientific journal. A good abstract adheres to brevity.

The limited number of words required for the research abstract means that every word included in the abstract is necessary and should be coherent. Important information should fit into one paragraph. This format requires a little bit of thinking and practice for the beginning researcher.

● TENSE OF THE ABSTRACT

In what tense should the abstract be written?

The abstract is usually written in the past tense because the investigation has transpired.

However, the statement of facts in, say, the results and discussion and the conclusion, must be in the present tense. As a general rule:

- Any statements of general fact should be written using the present tense.
- Reporting of research already conducted should be mentioned and explained using the past tense.
- If the subject of your sentence is your study or the article you are writing (e.g. “Our study demonstrates...,” or “Here, we show...”), then you should use the present tense.
- If you are stating a conclusion or an interpretation, use the present tense.
- If the subject of your sentence is an actual result or observation (e.g. “Mice in Group B developed...”), you would use the past tense.

• FINAL NOTES

Mark your style by deviating a little from the convention. The point is, that the abstract should be interesting enough such that readers will want to read your investigation, learn from it, or skip it because it’s not directly relevant to their interest. Since you want others to discover your work, select keywords or phrases that capture the essence of your research.

Popular search engines like Chrome, Firefox, Microsoft Edge, or Safari need these keywords to effectively serve those who look for information on the issue that you care to spend your time, money, and effort.